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## BAY AREA

# East Bay city reverses course on HOA-controlled Flock Safety cameras

By **Aldo Toledo**, Staff Writer

Aug 17, 2026





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East Bay city reverses course on HOA-controlled Flock Safety cameras

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A Contra Costa County city is reversing its decision to let a homeowners association use and have access to Flock Safety cameras set up at a golf course community.

The city of Brentwood had permitted four Flock cameras to be installed at the entrances and exits of the Shadow Lakes development. But amid backlash from the community and privacy advocates, the city says the surveillance permit was approved by “mistake.”

On Monday, Brentwood Mayor Susannah Meyer told the Chronicle the city has canceled the HOA’s permit because the cameras were installed within the public right-of-way, which requires a separate permit.

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After a City Council vote last week, the city has “initiated the process” of canceling the permit, Meyer said, referring to a city of Brentwood statement.

City officials said inspectors will go out and verify that the cameras in the public right-of-way are removed. If they aren’t, “the city may perform the restoration and recover its costs from the permittee,” the statement said.

The Shadow Lakes Homeowners Association could not immediately be reached for comment.

The idea that Flock cameras, which are normally used by municipalities and other government agencies, could be controlled and have footage reviewed by the HOA board drew outrage from the community and critics of Flock.

According to [the East Bay Times](#), some residents in the Shadow Lakes community of nearly 800 homes were unaware of the surveillance technology.

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“This is not a gated community. It’s a public street, and the people driving on it aren’t all members of the HOA,” said Nathan Fruth, according to the East Bay Times. “If the city wants cameras on public streets, that’s a decision that should be made by the city with public oversight,” Fruth added. “It shouldn’t be something a private organization can decide on its own.”

The cameras were installed ostensibly to address “ongoing safety concerns,” [according to ABC7](#). But during a City Council meeting last week, city officials acknowledged that they had mistakenly approved the HOA’s permit.

Brentwood officials said the permit was approved “under the mistaken belief” that the association was applying through the city’s existing police department camera program, which has dozens of license plate readers across the city.

The about-face in Brentwood comes as multiple California cities have canceled or suspended their contracts with Flock amid safety concerns. The criticism has prompted Flock Safety to make policy and system reforms to address the backlash, including [creating “guardrails”](#) and dropping the default retention period for data from 30 days to seven.

Matthew Guariglia, a senior policy analyst at the Electronic Frontier Foundation, [wrote in a post](#) on Friday that those “reforms are a combination of long overdue changes along with some cosmetic fixes that fail to address the fundamental dangers of this technology.”

“We should not be letting companies decide how much privacy we deserve,” Guariglia wrote. “If our privacy is determined by how much surveillance technology vendors decide is too much surveillance, then we’re really out of luck.”

Aug 17, 2026



**Aldo Toledo**

BREAKING NEWS REPORTER



Adalberto “Aldo” Toledo is a breaking news reporter with the Chronicle. He is a Venezuelan American from a family of longtime journalists. Before joining the Chronicle in 2023, he reported on Peninsula governments and breaking news for the San Jose Mercury News. He also has bylines in the Dallas Morning News, Pittsburgh Post-Gazette and Champaign, Illinois News-Gazette. Raised in Texas, he studied journalism with a print news focus at the University of North Texas Mayborn School of Journalism, where he worked as news editor for the North Texas Daily student newspaper.

### **How to reach Aldo**

Email [aldo.toledo@sfchronicle.com](mailto:aldo.toledo@sfchronicle.com). To share tips securely, use Signal at @alidot29.61.

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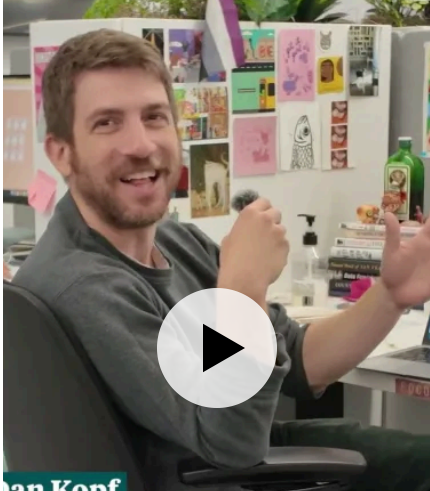
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